

Phase 9b Whimsical Localization

Branch: phase-9b-whimsical-localization · Current commit while report was generated: 2e6937d

Goal: increase whimsy and Harrisonburg local character while preserving the Phase 9 app structure, touch clarity, and calm reading surfaces.

The uploaded Harrisonburg reference was used as a cue sheet, not copied literally. The live implementation is CSS/HTML-first; generated assets remain prototypes in `public/assets/prototypes/phase-9b/`.

Reference Cues Extracted

Shape language	Courthouse/cupola silhouette, red-roofed civic massing, brick downtown blocks, crosswalk diagonals, market tents, street grid, Blue Ridge horizon.
Line quality	Simplified paper-cut silhouettes and soft shadows fit the exhibit better than photographic detail.
Density	The reference is visually dense; the exhibit keeps only a few local gestures so title, button, and cards stay clear.
Color mood	Warm newsprint, purple/gold accents, brick red, copper teal, autumn greens/oranges, blue ridge haze.
Whimsy level	Tiny figures, balloons, market stalls, and newspaper boxes add civic life without making the tone childish.

What Got More Whimsical

The Breeze Parade gained a CSS Blue Ridge horizon, civic cupola, market stalls, more local storefront character, richer crosswalk geometry, and a slightly more object-like newsbox. Threshold, Memory Rail, and Class-of tray gained small local-memory accents. Follow the Strings received only a faint corner warmth treatment.

What Stayed Restrained

Reading Drawer, Open Drawer, and Editor’s Table stayed text-first. The new decorative work avoids the body text areas, does not add form controls, and does not change the exhibit section structure. Reduced-motion behavior remains intact because the new local shapes are static.

Draft Assets



harrisonburg-parade-landscape-reference-draft.png

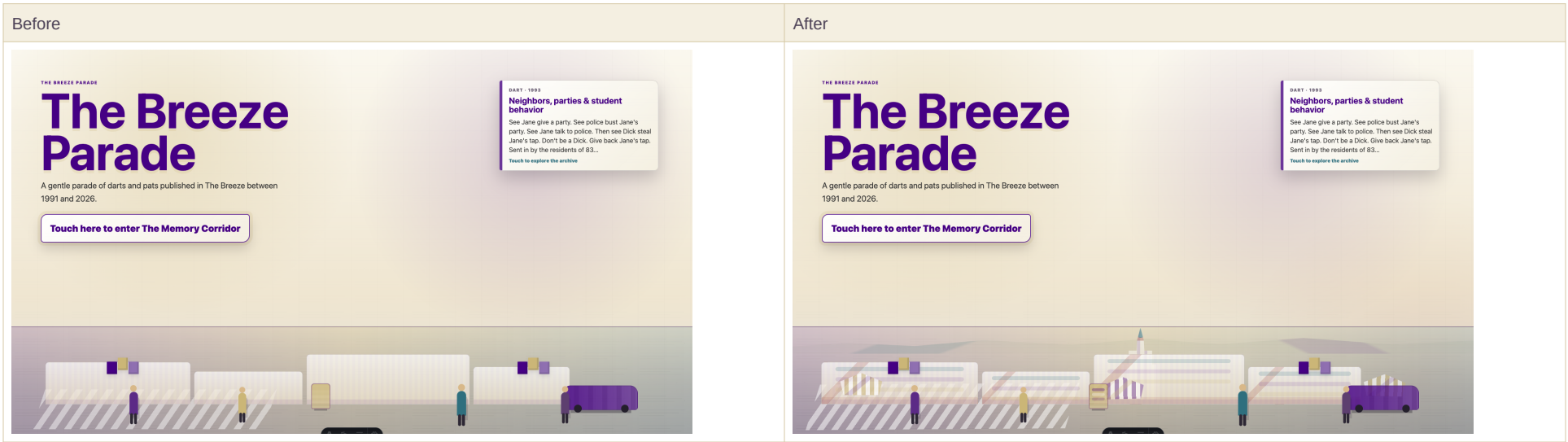


harrisonburg-parade-portrait-reference-draft.png

Generated assets are draft background concepts only. They are useful for art direction but not integrated directly into the live app.

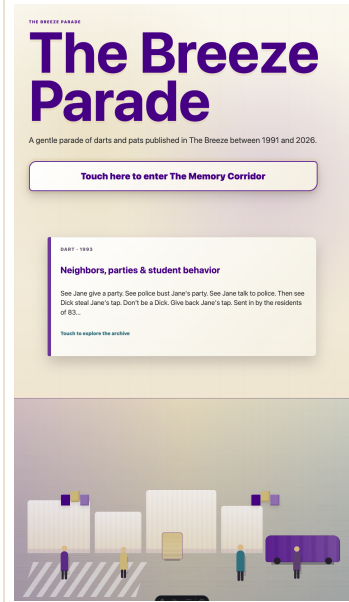
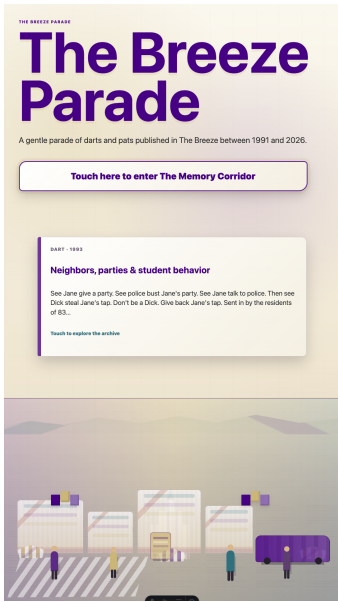
Asset	Dimensions	Recommendation
harrisonburg-parade-landscape-reference-draft.png	3840x2160	Strong direction for future attractor art; review accidental marks and title/card contrast before production use.
harrisonburg-parade-portrait-reference-draft.png	2160x3840	Promising portrait poster composition; review clipping overlap and crop behavior before integration.

The Breeze Parade, landscape



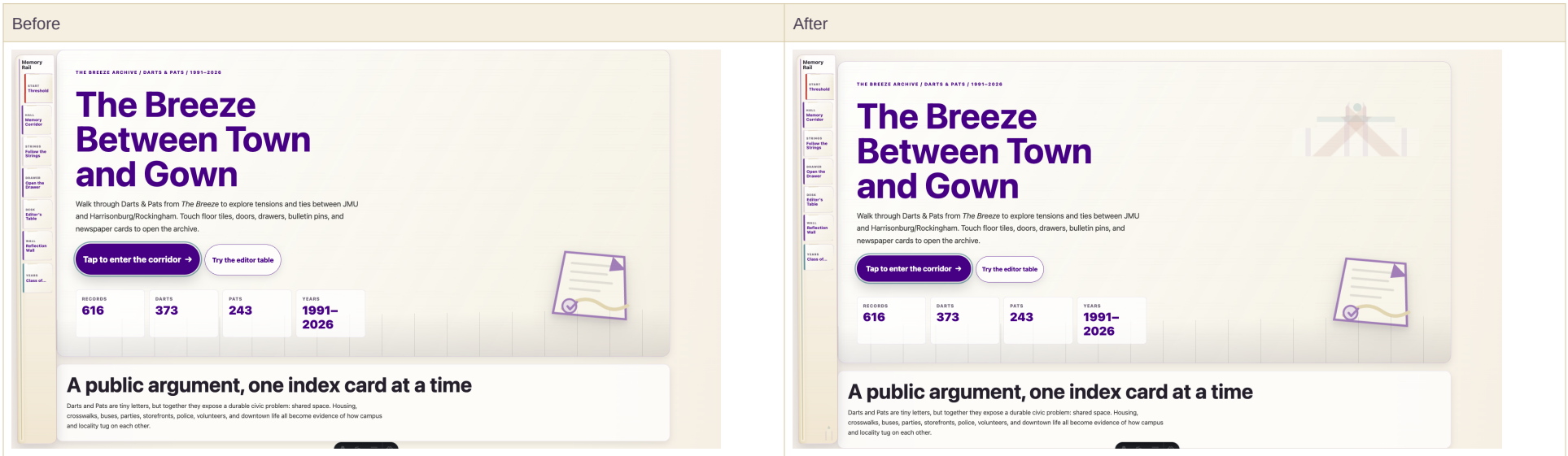
The updated live scene adds local civic silhouette, ridge line, stalls, crosswalk rhythm, and storefront character while keeping the title and touch target clear.

The Breeze Parade, portrait

Before	After
 The 'Before' portrait layout features a vertical poster design. At the top, the title 'The Breeze Parade' is in large purple font, with a subtitle 'A gentle parade of darts and pats published in The Breeze between 1991 and 2026.' below it. A purple button with white text 'Touch here to enter The Memory Corridor' is positioned below the subtitle. Further down, a white box contains the text 'Neighbors, parties & student behavior' and a paragraph of text. At the bottom, there is a stylized illustration of a street scene with buildings, a bus, and people.	 The 'After' portrait layout is identical to the 'Before' layout, maintaining the same vertical poster design with the title, subtitle, button, text box, and street scene illustration.

The portrait scene keeps the poster layout: text remains in the upper field and the local street character stays in the lower third.

Threshold accents

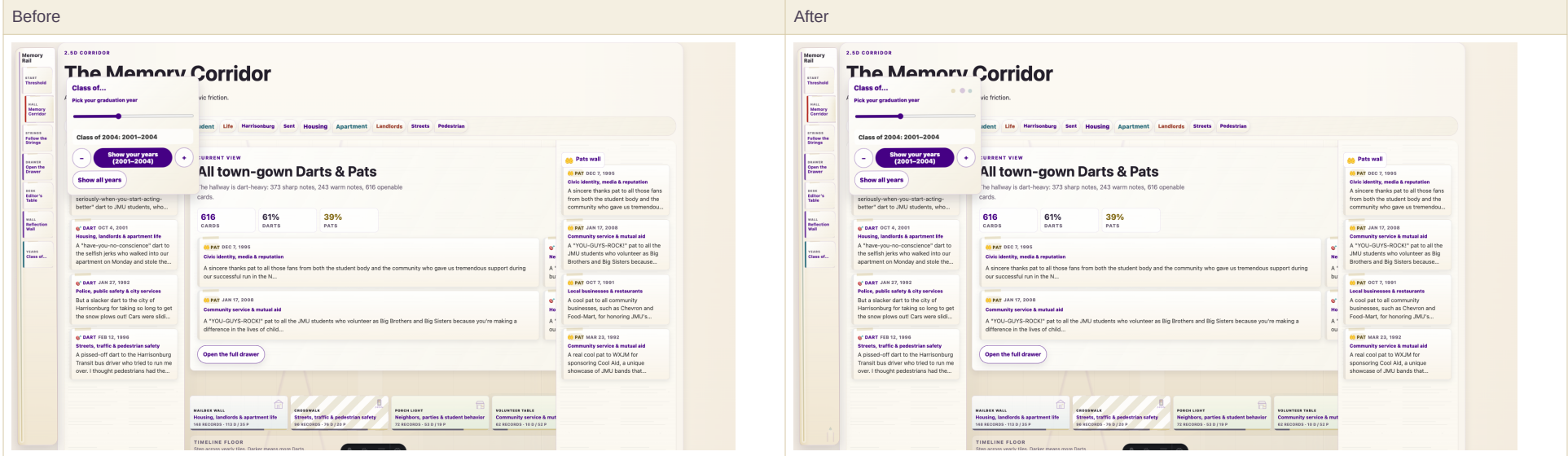


Memory Rail accents

Before	After
 The 'Before' image shows a vertical 'Memory Rail' on the left side of a large white workspace. The rail is a simple vertical bar with a light beige background and a thin dark border. It contains a list of items: 'START Threshold', 'WALL Memory Controller', 'STIMULI Follow the Strings', 'INSTRUC Open the Drawer?', 'DESK Editor's Table', 'WALL Multifunction Wall', and 'CLASS Class of...'. Each item is in a small, light-colored box with a colored header (red, purple, blue, green) and a dark title. The rail is positioned on the left edge of the workspace.	 The 'After' image shows the same 'Memory Rail' on the left side of the workspace, but with a new design element: a small, light-colored cupola or tab is added to the top of the rail, centered horizontally. The rail itself remains the same as in the 'Before' image, with the same list of items and layout.

The rail gains a tiny cupola/tab accent. It remains a tactile navigation object, not a StoryMap sidebar.

Class-of tray accents

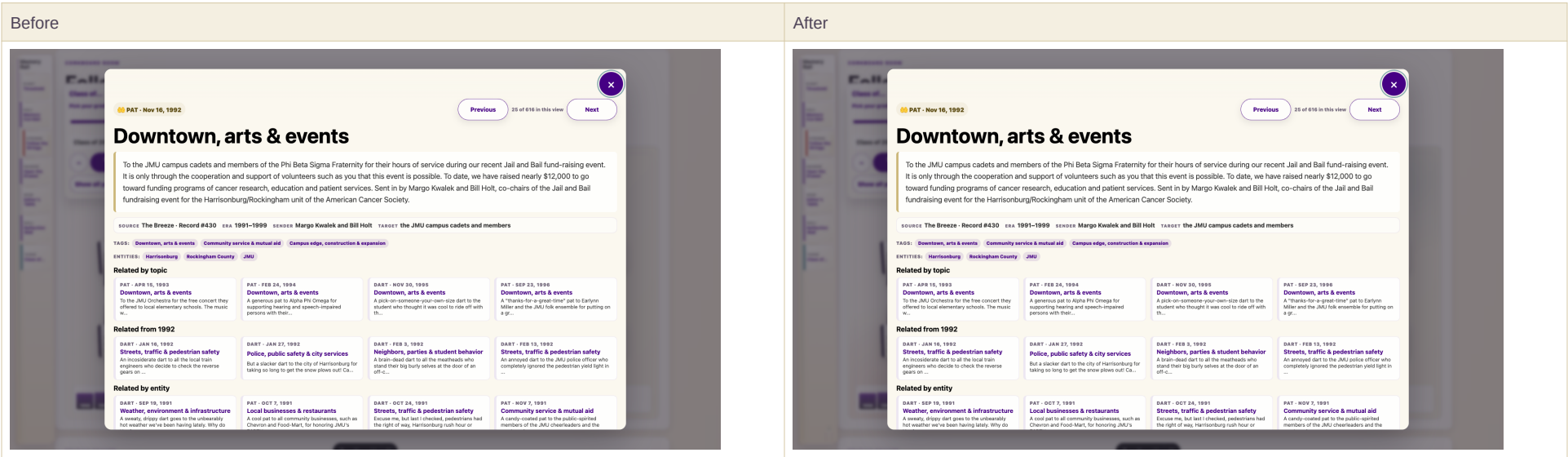


The tray gains a small memory-balloon accent while preserving the large range control and action button.

The image displays two side-by-side screenshots of a digital memory board interface, likely for a class or organization. Both screens show a central theme, 'Housing, landlords & apartment life', with various related topics branching out. The left screen is titled 'Follow the Strings' and the right screen is titled 'Follow the Strings' (though the text is partially obscured). The interface includes a 'Memory Rail' on the left, a 'Class of...' dropdown menu, and a 'Show your years (2001-2004)' button. The central theme is 'Housing, landlords & apartment life' (148 RECORDS / 113 DARTS / 55 PATS). The right screen shows a different central theme, 'Housing, landlords & apartment life' (148 RECORDS / 113 DARTS / 55 PATS). The interface also includes a 'Show all years' button and a 'Show your years (2001-2004)' button. The right screen shows a different central theme, 'Housing, landlords & apartment life' (148 RECORDS / 113 DARTS / 55 PATS). The interface also includes a 'Show all years' button and a 'Show your years (2001-2004)' button. The right screen shows a different central theme, 'Housing, landlords & apartment life' (148 RECORDS / 113 DARTS / 55 PATS). The interface also includes a 'Show all years' button and a 'Show your years (2001-2004)' button.

Only a faint color warmth was added. The room remains self-contained and readable; no new filters or dashboard controls were introduced.

Reading Drawer restrained



The drawer remains essentially unchanged and text-forward; no decorative layer was added to the reading surface.

Editor's Table restrained

Before

Memory Ball

CLASS Yearbook

WALL Memory Corridor

STORIES Follow the Strings

STORIES Open the Drawer

TEXT Editor's Table

WALL Reflection Wall

CLASS Class of...

NO-SCORE INTERPRETIVE GAME

You be the Breeze editor

Read the card cold. Was it printed as a Dart or a Pat?

Some cards are masked because they name their own form.

WAS IT PRINTED AS...

DartPat

A "staying-in-touch" [form hidden] to The Breeze for delivering copies that can be picked up by alumni who don't live in Harrisonburg at various locations including Cinnamon Bear, Valley Fitness and Martin's. From a Madison College graduate.

Reveal how The Breeze printed it

New card

No points. Just interpretation.

REFLECTION WALL

What the wall remembers

All entries are drawn from Darts & Pats published in The Breeze, James Madison University's student newspaper. They are presented as historical evidence of perception, humor, grievance, gratitude, and civic memory—not as neutral measurements of the town-gown relationship.

After

Memory Ball

CLASS Yearbook

WALL Memory Corridor

STORIES Follow the Strings

STORIES Open the Drawer

TEXT Editor's Table

WALL Reflection Wall

CLASS Class of...

NO-SCORE INTERPRETIVE GAME

You be the Breeze editor

Read the card cold. Was it printed as a Dart or a Pat?

Some cards are masked because they name their own form.

WAS IT PRINTED AS...

DartPat

A "learn-to-be-respectful" [form hidden] to the guy who urinated on the window of our neighbors downstairs, kicked down their door and threatened to kill them We really appreciate your stupidity. From four girls who expected more from the JMU male population but guess we still have to wait until you all grow up.

Reveal how The Breeze printed it

New card

No points. Just interpretation.

REFLECTION WALL

What the wall remembers

All entries are drawn from Darts & Pats published in The Breeze, James Madison University's student newspaper. They are presented as historical evidence of perception, humor, grievance, gratitude, and civic memory—not as neutral measurements of the town-gown relationship.

The editor game remains focused on reading and Dart/Pat interpretation, with no added visual clutter.

Readability And Touch Clarity

Readability is preserved because the local additions sit mostly in decorative zones: Parade bottom scene, threshold background, rail edge, and Class-of tray corner. The title, clipping card, touch-to-enter button, rail targets, Class-of controls, reading drawer, and editor card remain HTML with their existing sizing and focus behavior.

Touch clarity was smoke-tested in landscape and portrait. The new CSS shapes are not controls and do not introduce hover-only behavior or small interaction targets.

Recommended / Rejected Assets

Strongest future integration candidate: the landscape Parade reference draft, after visual review and contrast scrim testing. The portrait draft is also promising but needs more overlap testing. The generated assets should not be used as live production backgrounds until checked for accidental readable marks and kiosk contrast. No generated art should be applied to the Reading Drawer or Editor's Table reading area.

StoryMap / Dashboard Check

The Phase 9b changes reinforce physical exhibit metaphors: parade, storefront, civic silhouette, rail tab, and ticket-like tray. They do not add numbered chapter dots, map-first layout, corporate content blocks, search boxes, or dashboard-style metrics.

Remaining Risks

- The new cupola shape should remain an accent; repeating it everywhere would make the exhibit motif too literal.
- The generated Parade drafts are attractive but could reduce contrast if integrated without a scrim.
- Portrait kiosks should be reviewed again after any production background art is added.
- Human visual review should confirm the local references feel Harrisonburg-like without suggesting official city/JMU/Breeze branding.